

Strategy 4 — Running Ads That Convert

Only Run Ads Once You've Tested Content First

Here's what everyone gets wrong about ads: They think it's about budget. It's not.

It's about proof.

That organic post that blew up? That's your ad. That reel that generated 50 DMs? That's your winner. That carousel that got saved 1,000 times? That's your money maker.

Ads don't create demand. They amplify what already works.

The Testing Hierarchy

Never guess with your money. Test with your time first.

The sequence:

1. Post organically.
2. Track what resonates.
3. Identify top performers.
4. Boost winners only.
5. Scale what converts.

The metrics that matter:

- Engagement rate (not just likes)
- Save-to-reach ratio
- DM conversations started
- Profile visits generated
- Link clicks achieved

If it didn't work for free, it won't work for a fee.

Platform Ad Breakdown

Each platform has its own ad physics. Respect them or waste money.

Instagram/Facebook Ads

The precision play.

What works:

- Boosted Reels (native feel)
- Story ads (high intent)
- Carousel ads (education + conversion)
- Collection ads (portfolio showcase)

Targeting gold:

- **Interests:** Design tools, AI platforms, creative software.
- **Behaviors:** Small business owners, marketing managers.
- **Lookalikes:** Your email list, website visitors.
- **Custom:** People who engaged with your content.

Budget reality: Start at \$20-50/day. Scale based on CPA (cost per acquisition).

TikTok Ads

The volume game.

What works:

- Spark Ads (boost your organic content)
- In-feed natives (blend seamlessly)
- TopView (expensive but effective)

Why it's different:

- Younger demo, but decision-makers are aging up.
- Creative-first platform (polish kills performance).
- Rapid testing needed (burn and learn).

Pro move: Use Spark Ads to amplify viral content while it's hot. Ride the wave.

LinkedIn Ads

The B2B backend.

Worth it for:

- High-ticket services (\$10k+ projects)
- Enterprise clients
- Retainer relationships

Skip it for:

- Quick projects
- Creative work
- Small business clients

The CPM is brutal. But the client quality can justify it.

The Creative Formula

Your ad creative is 80% of performance. The platform mechanics are just 20%.

Anatomy of converting ads:

1. **Hook** (0-3 seconds): Pattern interrupt, problem agitation, or a transformation teaser.
2. **Story** (3-10 seconds): Show the process, build credibility, and create desire.
3. **Proof** (10-15 seconds): Results speak, show social proof, and demonstrate value.
4. **CTA** (last 2 seconds): A single action with a clear benefit and an easy next step.

Without a CTA, it's just entertainment.

CTAs That Actually Convert

Generic CTAs are money furnaces.

What burns cash: "Learn more," "Sign up," "Get started," "Contact us."

What drives action:

- "Get your brand audit in 48 hours."
- "Download the AI prompt playbook."
- "Book your strategy call — 3 spots left."
- "See how we 3x'd their conversions."

Specificity sells. Vagueness repels.

The Offer Ladder

Smart advertisers don't sell on the first touch. They build relationships.

The progression:

1. **Free value** (prompt pack, audit template) → Build trust, capture email.
2. **Low-ticket** (\$47-297 mini-course or templates) → Qualify buyers, offset ad spend.
3. **Mid-ticket** (\$2-5k project) → Core offer, main revenue.
4. **High-ticket** (\$10k+ retainers) → Premium positioning, recurring revenue.

Each step funds the next. Each buyer reveals themselves.

Retargeting Magic

Cold traffic is expensive. Warm traffic is profitable.

Retargeting segments:

- Watched 75%+ of your video
- Visited your website
- Engaged with your posts
- Added to cart but didn't buy
- Past clients (for upsells)

The rule: Spend 70% on cold traffic, 30% on retargeting. The 30% drives 50% of revenue.

Testing Framework

Opinions lose money. Data makes money.

Test variables:

- Creative (biggest impact)
- Copy angles
- Audiences
- Placements
- CTAs

But test smart: Test one variable at a time with \$50-100 per test for at least 3-4 days. Kill losers fast. Scale winners hard.

Budget Allocation

Your first \$1,000 in ad spend:

- 40% testing different creatives
- 30% testing audiences
- 20% retargeting engaged users
- 10% held for scaling winners

Month 1: Learn

Month 2: Optimize

Month 3: Scale

Most quit in Month 1. Winners push through.

Tracking That Matters

Vanity metrics kill ad budgets.

Track:

- Cost per lead (CPL)
- Cost per acquisition (CPA)
- Return on ad spend (ROAS)
- Lifetime value (LTV)
- Payback period

Ignore: Impressions, reach, frequency, and click-through rate (unless testing creative). Money in, money out. Everything else is noise.

Common Ad Mistakes

Learn from the graveyard:

- **Mistake 1:** Running ads to your homepage.
Fix: Create specific landing pages.
- **Mistake 2:** Broad targeting.
Fix: Niche down, then niche again.
- **Mistake 3:** Selling on the first touch.
Fix: Build the relationship first.
- **Mistake 4:** Set and forget.
Fix: Daily monitoring, weekly optimization.
- **Mistake 5:** Competing on price.
Fix: Compete on value and positioning.

The Multiplier Effect

Ads + Organic = Exponential

Your ads drive awareness. Your organic builds trust. Together they create inevitability.

The ecosystem:

- Ads bring new eyes.
- Content builds the relationship.
- Social proof closes deals.
- Results create testimonials.
- Testimonials become new ads.

Full circle. Compound returns.

When to Start

Not day one. Not year one. But somewhere in between.

You're ready when:

- You have consistent organic reach.
- You know what content converts.
- You have backend systems ready.
- You can invest without stress.
- You understand your numbers.

Start small. Test everything. Scale what works.

The Bottom Line

Ads are amplifiers, not magic wands. They make good things better and bad things worse.

If your organic content doesn't convert, fix that first. If your offer isn't clear, clarify it. If your systems can't handle volume, build them.

Then, and only then, pour gas on the fire.